

Reference — Omura (2004), *Trees, Forests and Religion in Japan*

Citation

Omura, Hiroshi (2004). "Trees, Forests and Religion in Japan." *Mountain Research and Development* 24(2): 179–182. Published 1 May 2004 (International Mountain Society / BioOne). DOI: [10.1659/0276-4741\(2004\)024\[0179:TFARIJ\]2.0.CO;2](https://doi.org/10.1659/0276-4741(2004)024[0179:TFARIJ]2.0.CO;2) Type: Journal article (4 pages, not a book). Access: Open Access (marked on the publisher page). 25 citations at time of capture (2026-10-02).

Full text (BioOne page)

- Landing page: [https://bioone.org/doi/abs/10.1659/0276-4741\(2004\)024\[0179%3ATFARIJ\]2.0.CO%3B2](https://bioone.org/doi/abs/10.1659/0276-4741(2004)024[0179%3ATFARIJ]2.0.CO%3B2)
- PDF (publisher, open access): [https://bioone.org/journals/mountain-research-and-development/volume-24/issue-2/0276-4741_2004_024_0179_TFARIJ_2.0.CO_2/Trees-Forests-and-Religion-in-Japan/10.1659/0276-4741\(2004\)024\[0179:TFARIJ\]2.0.CO%3B2.pdf](https://bioone.org/journals/mountain-research-and-development/volume-24/issue-2/0276-4741_2004_024_0179_TFARIJ_2.0.CO_2/Trees-Forests-and-Religion-in-Japan/10.1659/0276-4741(2004)024[0179:TFARIJ]2.0.CO%3B2.pdf)
- Other copies listed: [ResearchGate](#), [Scribd](#)

Local copy: `omura_2004_trees_forests_religion_japan_fulltext.pdf` in this folder (7 pages; the article is pp. 179–182, the rest is adjacent items from the same issue). **Not committed to git** — BioOne's terms limit use to personal/educational/non-commercial, and the repo is public, so keep it local or link to the publisher.

Extracted text (from screenshot of the publisher page)

TL;DR: According to an ancient Shinto belief, a god descended to a high pine on an elegant mountain, to exist in a large or old tree as mentioned in this paper, and the precinct of a shrine is distinguished by special trees.

Abstract: According to an ancient Shinto belief, a god descended to a high pine on an elegant mountain, to exist in a large or old tree. Sacred places, despite occupying only 0.55% of Japanese territory, have been marked by shrines for many years. The precinct of a shrine is distinguished by special trees. Twigs with leaves of *Cleyra japonica* or *Illicium religiosum* are offered to a god or the soul of a dead person. More than 15 species in Japan have been identified for religious use. Because sacred forests and trees have significant roles, preserving a solemn atmosphere as well as the natural environment, they should be protected and conserved as a heritage for citizens.

Key facts from the full text (pp. 179–182)

- **Scale:** shrines and temples manage about **208,000 ha** of forest = **0.55% of Japan**, in roughly **34,000** separate forests, average **6.1 ha** (often larger than a typical private forest). Mainly **evergreen broad-leaved trees mixed with sugi (Cryptomeria)**, the dominant species of warm-temperate SW Japan.
- **Religious trees:** more than 15 species, mostly in SW Japan. Examples: Sakaki (*Cleyra japonica*, a pioneer species, offered at shrines), Ogamatanoki (*Michelia compressa*, planted at shrine gates), pine, bamboo, camphor, sugi, and *Cyclobalanopsis* oaks (acorns were a staple food of ancient SW Japan).
- **Protection by belief:** cutting a large or old tree is said to bring a god's curse. Large old trees are being recognised as natural monuments, landmarks and climate records.
- **Nara precedent:** the 300-ha Mikasayama forest at Kasuga-taisha (Nara). Timber cutting and hunting have been banned since AD 841. It is a climax forest with a pure *Podocarpus nagi* stand, a natural monument (1924, special 1956) and a World Heritage Site (1998). Deer are protected as messengers of the gods.
- **Restoration precedent:** the Ise shrine forest was degraded by over-cutting for firewood, and the government revegetated it in the 1950s. Today it is a broad-leaved forest mixed with hinoki. Meiji-jingu (Tokyo, 1920) is a planted forest designed on ecological principles and now looks natural.

- **Pioneer pine:** pollen records show 72% of the original forest had been lost by 1500 BP and replaced by secondary pine, which fits the idea that people expect pine to recover after cutting or fire.
- **Author's argument:** the belief that science can manage forests led to cutting and planting in areas that were formerly natural forest (citing Shidei 1985), while forests preserved for centuries on religious grounds have protected both atmosphere and regional environment.

Why it matters to this project

- **Native broadleaf reforestation:** shrine forests are living reference ecosystems for the target mix (evergreen broadleaf with some conifer) in warm-temperate Nara. They are also possible seed and species sources. Cross-check the species against `docs/meetings/mizuho_broadleaf_species_list.md` (that file does not mention Sakaki, Ogatamanoki, *Podocarpus nagi* or *Cyclobalanopsis* — worth adding if they suit Mitsue's elevation).
- **Cultural story:** a peer-reviewed basis for pitching reforestation to villagers and shrines as continuing an old Japanese practice, not as an imported idea. This supports the sugi-monoculture-to-mixed-forest narrative and the "planting for the next 100 years" framing.
- **Precedents:** Ise (degraded, then replanted by government in the 1950s) and Meiji-jingu (ecologically designed planting) support the feasibility claim. Mikasayama (Nara, 1,100+ years protected) shows long-term protection works in the same prefecture.
- **Related work:** James Hill's shrine-forest paleoecology (`docs/energy-forest/history/james_hill_information.md`).

Caveats

- Short (4 pages), descriptive and from 2004. Most statistics are cited from Japanese books (Tujii 1995, Yagishita 1986, Honda 2002) that are not checked here.
- Several word-origin explanations (for example *matsu* as "waiting for a god") are folk etymologies. Do not quote them as linguistic fact.
- The claim that Japanese tree-religion came from the Eurasian continent is speculative.
- Verify the area figures (208,000 ha, 34,000 forests, 6.1 ha) against a current source before using them in public documents.